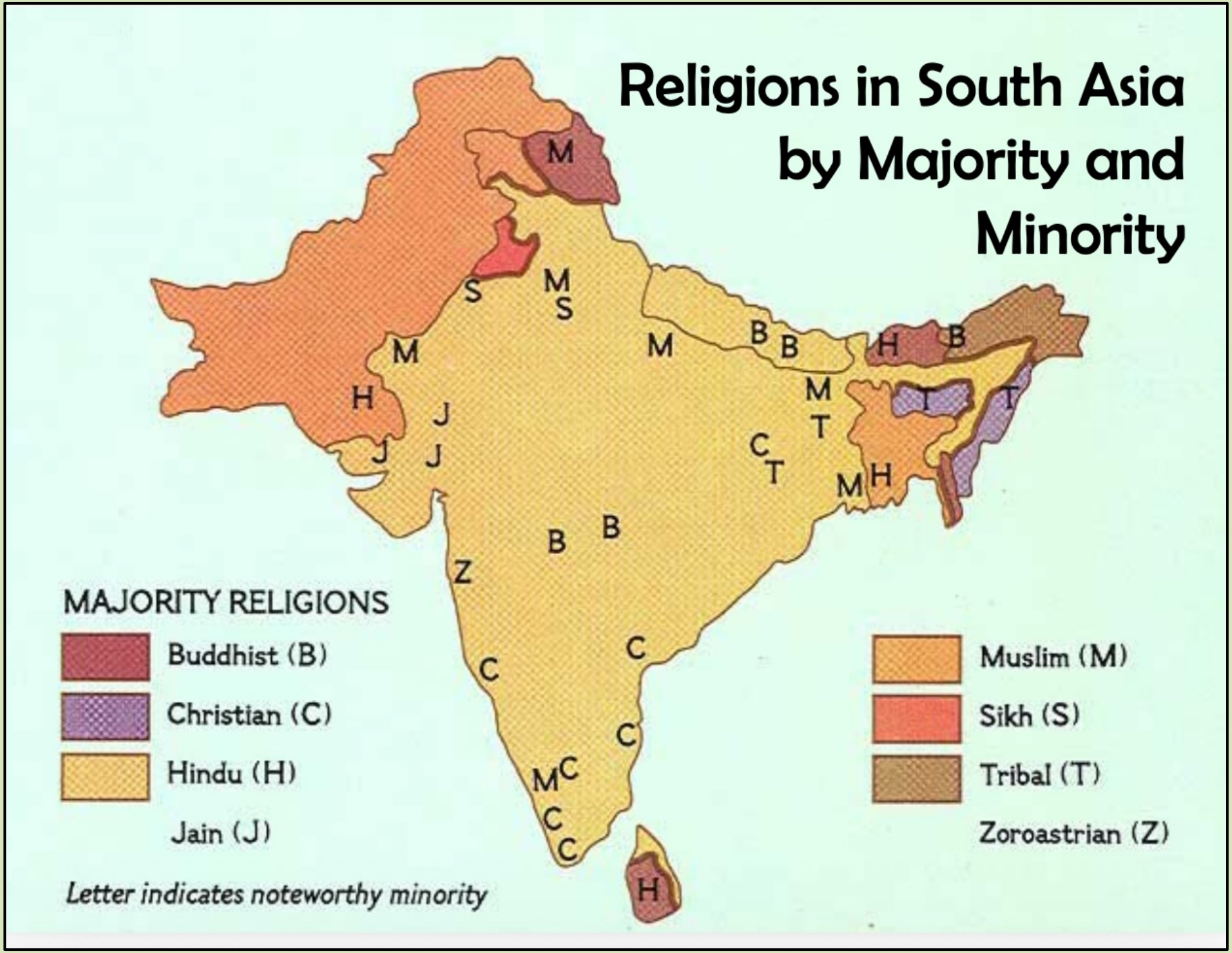
Lecture 10

Religions in India: Encounters, Adaptations and Transregional Influences

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Religions in South Asia by Majority and Minority



Religions in the Indian sub-continent

India is not simply a land of “many religions”

Religious plurality • diversity within religions • religion as lived experience

Interaction between religious communities

Religion’s relationship with society and politics

From studying religions only objectively → religion as a social and historical phenomenon

Religions originating in India

Hinduism
Buddhism
Jainism
Sikhism

Religions that arrived from outside

Christianity
Judaism
Islam
Zoroastrianism
Bahá'í faith

Plurality ≠ Pluralism

PLURALITY: many religious traditions exist

PLURALISM: different religious communities negotiate their coexistence

Accommodation • interaction • borrowing • negotiation • competition • conflict

Key question: How do people live with religious difference?

Religion Is Not One Homogeneous Entity

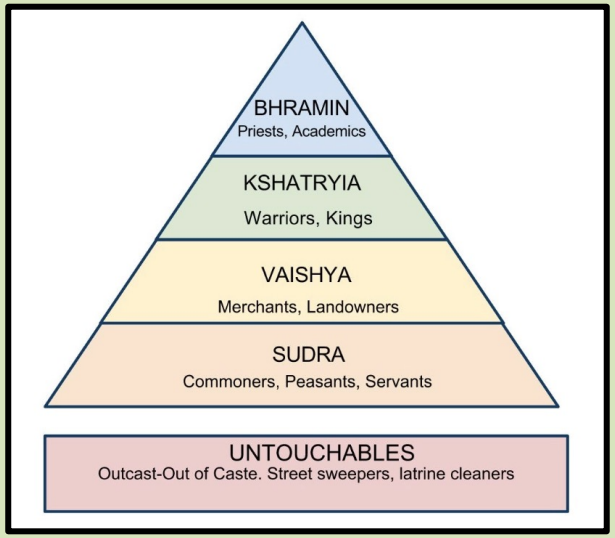
Religions are internally diverse

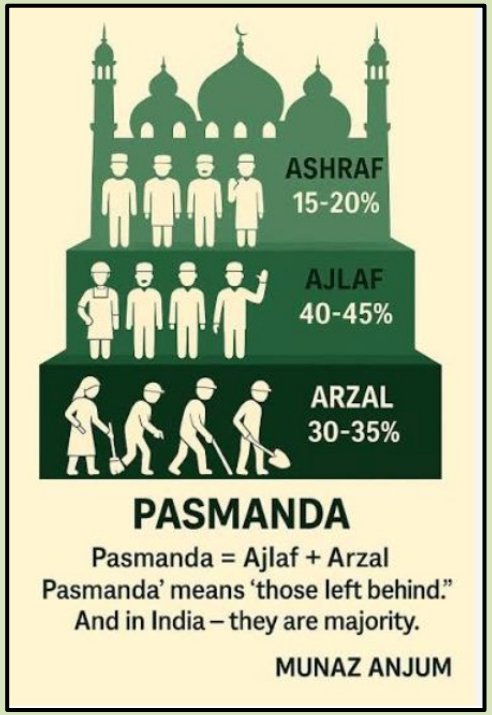
Hinduism: Shaiva • Vaishnava • Shakta • Bhakti • regional and sectarian traditions

Islam • Buddhism • Christianity • Jainism • Sikhism are also internally diverse

Schools, sects, philosophies, rituals, regional variations, social practices and competing authorities

Religious boundaries exist, but are neither perfectly fixed nor internally uniform





Religion as Lived Experience

Religion is more than belief

BELIEF → PRACTICE → EXPERIENCE → SOCIAL LIFE

Food • worship • pilgrimage • death rituals • festivals

Sacred spaces • family practices • community institutions

Distinguish religion as doctrine from religion as lived practice

Remain mindful of the differences between the textual references and lived-experiences

Religion and Society Are Intertwined

Religion is embedded in social life

Caste • community • family • gender • economy

Political authority • social hierarchy • institutions

A temple can also be an economic institution, centre of redistribution, site of political authority, source of employment and marker of community identity

To understand religion historically, study the society in which it is practised

Tradition Is Not Static

Tradition → Adaptation → Innovation

Religious traditions evolve and reinterpret older practices

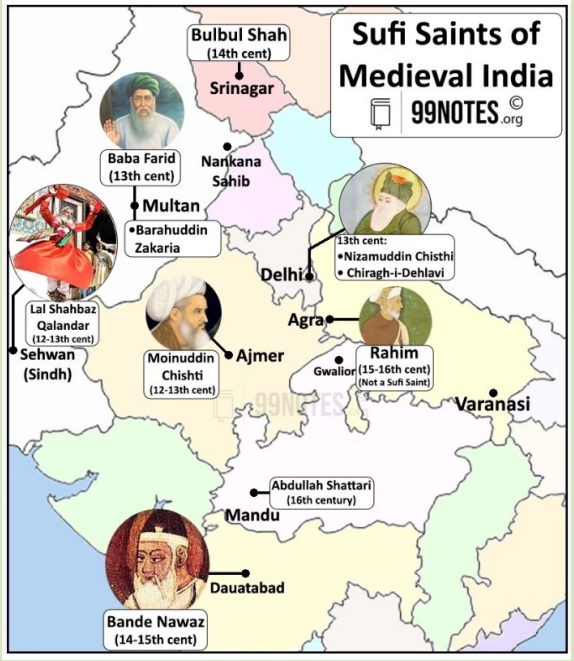
They generate new movements and respond to social change

They encounter other traditions

Tradition itself contains mechanisms of reinterpretation and innovation

Examples: Bhakti traditions • Kabir Panth • Ramakrishna Mission • Ambedkar's engagement with Buddhism





From Madan to the Indian Ocean

If religion is plural, lived, adaptive and socially embedded… how does it change when people move?

INDIA → SRI LANKA → SOUTHEAST ASIA → CHINA

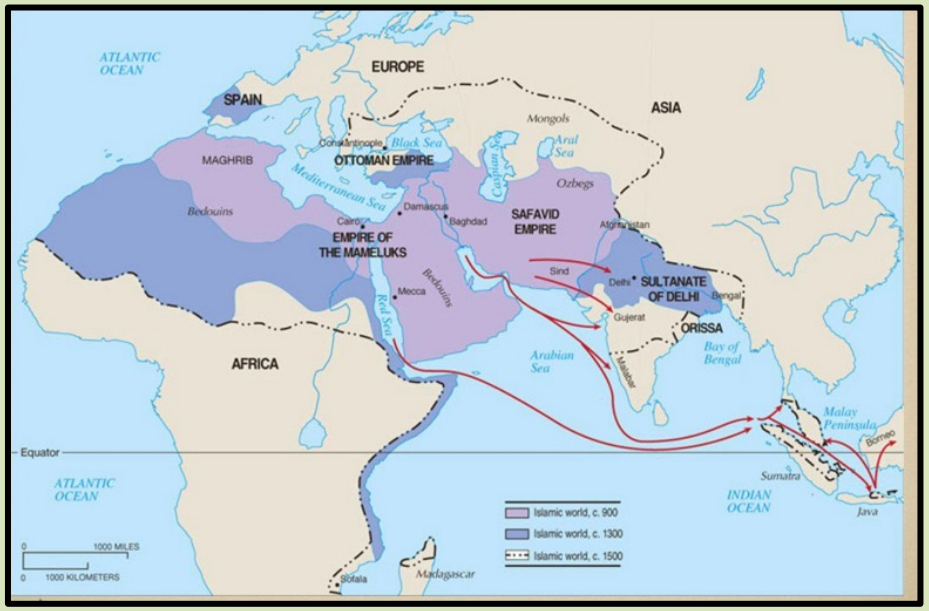
Movement also occurs back toward India

Merchants • monks • pilgrims • rulers

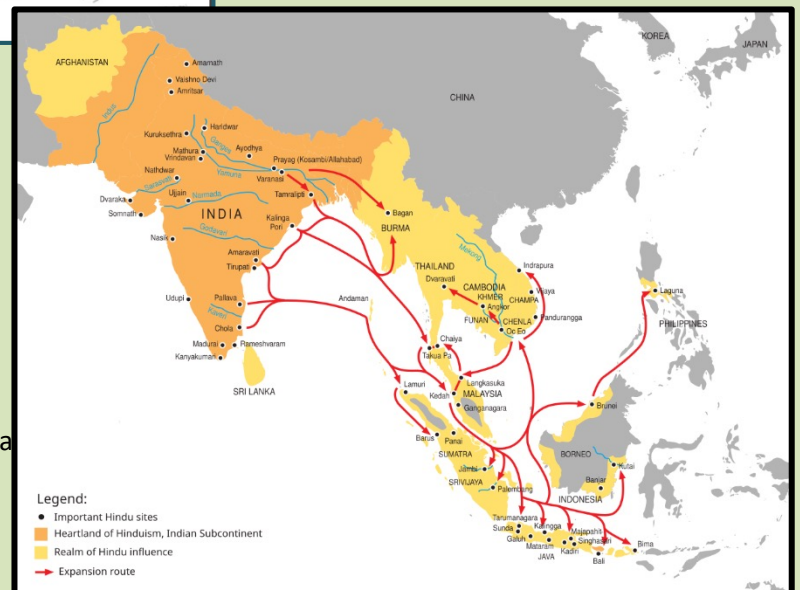
Religious traditions travel—but they also change as they travel



Spread of Buddhism in Southeast Asia



Spread of Islam to Southeast Asia



Spread of Hinduism in Southeast Asia

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V_ICzp64Vuo

Religious Encounters: Boundaries Can Be Porous

Hindu ↔ Buddhist ↔ Jain ↔ Islamic ↔ Christian

Interaction can produce: borrowing • adaptation • shared vocabulary

Shared sacred spaces • new institutions • new identities

Encounter does not necessarily mean conversion

Traditions may coexist, compete, borrow, adapt and influence artistic or political forms



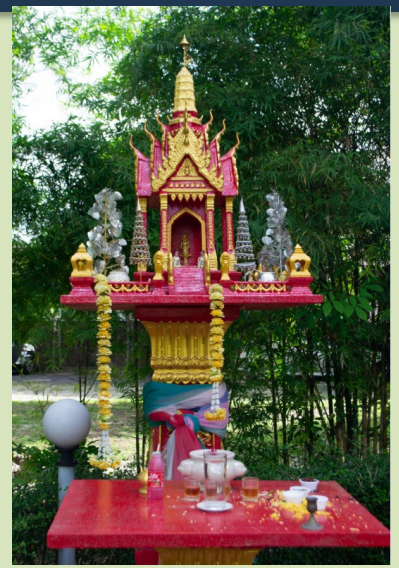
Temple in Bali, Indonesia



Mendut Temple, Java, Indonesia



Ramakien: Ramayana in Thailand



Thai religious practices



☛ One of the most compelling intersections between these traditions is the iconography of the Buddhist goddess Tara. While she is revered in Vajrayana as a bodhisattva and savior, her fierce forms, such as Mahachinakrama Tara, bear resemblance to the wrathful manifestations of Durga and Kali in Shakta worship. Similarly, the depiction of Yoginis, found in the Chausath Yogini temples of Hirapur and Ranipur-Jharial, echoes the Dakini cults of Vajrayana monasteries, where dakinis serve as enlightened wisdom beings aiding tantric practitioners.

Source: www.exoticindiaart.com/article/whispers-of-the-dakini-from-odisha-to-tibet-rise-of-buddhist-tantra/?srsltid=



Rethinking the “Spread” of Indian Religions

From “religious diffusion” to “religious circulation”

Traditional model: India → Southeast Asia

Dynamic model: India ↔ Sri Lanka ↔ Southeast Asia ↔ China

Agents and media: merchants • monks/teachers • pilgrims • rulers

Ships • texts • images • temples/monasteries • merchant guilds

Religion travelled because people travelled; what travelled was transformed in the process

The Indian Ocean Was a Cultural Space

The sea was not a barrier—it connected South India, Sri Lanka, the Bay of Bengal, Southeast Asia and South China

Movement involved: Goods + People + Ideas + Institutions + Rituals

Ports were places where merchants settled and religious specialists interacted

Ports also connected rulers, communities, languages, images and traditions

India → Southeast Asia: Who Carried Religion?

Not one agent, but several

Merchants → created mobility

Brahmans → ritual & kingship

Buddhist monks/teachers → monasteries, teachings & pilgrimage

Rulers → patronage & political appropriation

Artisans → images & material culture

Commercial mobility created conditions within which religious mobility became possible

Purnavarman: Religion Meets Local Kingship

West Java, c. 5th century • ruler of Tarumanagara

Devotee of Vishnu • Sanskrit inscription • South Indian/Grantha script

Sacred footprint (Vishnupada) • Indic royal titulature

India was not simply “copied”

Indic symbols were appropriated and reworked locally

Indic vocabulary + local political context = new cultural formation

Trade Routes Become Religious Routes

Tamil coast → Thai Peninsula → Malay Peninsula → Sumatra / Java → China

Evidence: Tamil Brahmi inscription at Klong Thom

Sanskrit inscriptions • Hindu imagery • Buddhist sites • merchant settlements

Merchant → settlement → community → religious presence

Resident communities allowed religious practices to become institutionalised

Buddhism: India ↔ Southeast Asia

Bengal / Nalanda ↕ Tamil & Andhra coasts ↕ Sri Lanka ↕ Sumatra / Java

- Balaputradeva of Suvarnadvipa (Sumatra) established a monastery at Nalanda
- Pala king Devapala granted villages to support it
- Southeast Asian rulers patronised institutions in India
- India provided religious learning; monks and teachers travelled between regions

Connected history: India ↔ Indonesia

Atisa: Religious Knowledge Travels by Merchant Ship

Atisa Dipankara, 982–1054

Bengal → Sumatra / Suvarnadvipa → Vikramashila → Tibet

He travelled to Indonesia on a merchant ship

The same ship could carry commodities and religious knowledge

Texts • ritual objects • languages • artistic styles • news • ideas • people

Nagapattinam: A Religious Crossroads

Tamil Coast

Hindu: Shiva temple • Vaishnava traditions

Buddhist: Cudamanivihara • Buddhist bronzes • monks & nuns

Maritime connections: Sriwijaya • China • Southeast Asia

One port → multiple religious worlds

A multi-religious sacred geography preceded and followed the Buddhist vihara

Religion Adapted, Not Simply Transplanted

At Nagapattinam, Buddhist images could employ Shaiva + Vaishnava + Buddhist visual/ritual vocabularies

Buddha • Avalokitesvara • Maitreya • Tara • votive stupas

Tamil inscriptions record monks, nuns, artisans and lay donors

Religious hybridity does not mean traditions simply merged

Different traditions borrowed, adapted and reinterpreted shared cultural forms

Southeast Asia → India: The Direction Also Reversed

Religion did not travel only outward from India

Sriwijaya → Nagapattinam

Sumatra → Nalanda

Southeast Asian rulers → Indian monasteries

Chinese donors → Tamil religious institutions

India was not simply the source: Indian religious centres became nodes in transregional networks

China and the Indian Peninsula: A Two-Way Maritime World

China ↔ Indian Ocean ↔ India

Nagapattinam: Chinese gold coins / donations associated with religious worship

Gifts from China to the Buddhist vihara

Quanzhou: Tamil + Chinese inscription • Shiva temple • Tamil merchant community

The readings do not establish a simple Chinese → India transmission

Better formulation: Chinese and Indian communities participated in a shared maritime religious environment

What Does This Tell Us About Religion?

- Premodern religion was: Mobile • Networked • Adaptive
- Plural • Reciprocal • Open-ended
- Religion travelled with people
- People travelled through commercial networks
- Networks created institutions; institutions created new cultural forms
- The history of religion is also a history of mobility

Conceptual Map: A Connected Religious World

PEOPLE: merchants • monks • rulers • pilgrims • artisans

INDIA ↔ SEA ↔ CHINA, with SOUTHEAST ASIA and SRI LANKA as connected nodes

Texts • images • rituals

Temples • monasteries • guilds

→ NEW RELIGIOUS / CULTURAL FORMS

Religions were not simply “exported”: they travelled through human networks and were translated into new contexts

Overarching Argument

Indian religions became historically significant beyond the subcontinent not because they remained unchanged as they travelled

—but because they could be carried, translated, appropriated and reinterpreted in different cultural environment

—new combinations of local and transregional elements emerged

Madan → religion as a social and plural phenomenon

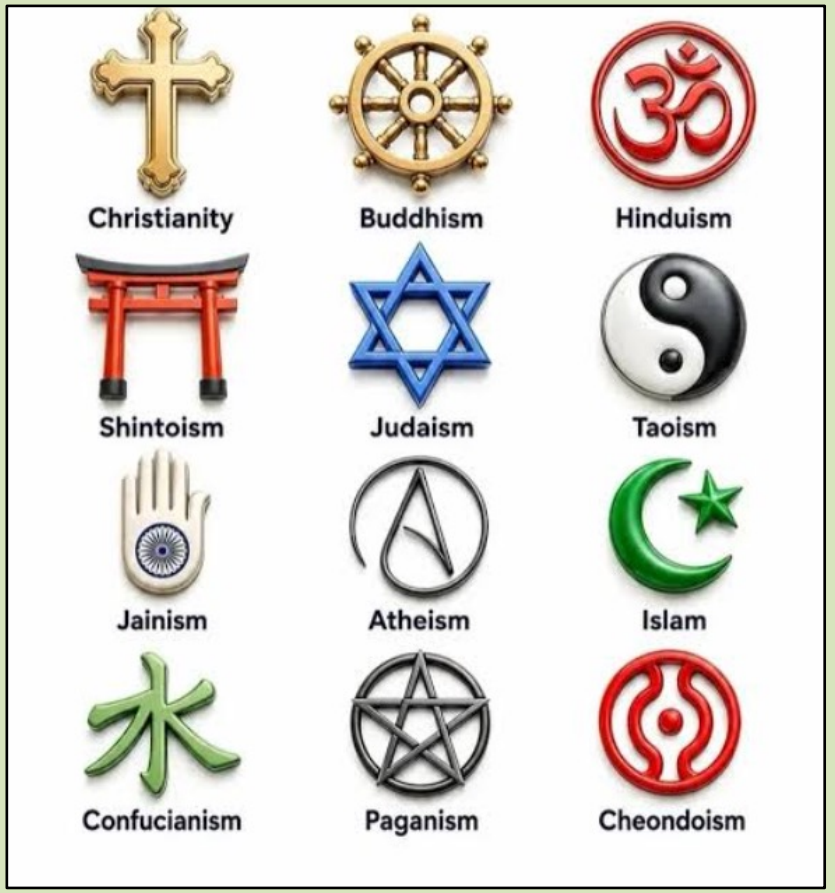
Guy → transmission through merchant and maritime networks

Ray → religious exchange and multi-religious cultural landscapes

The premodern world was highly interconnected, mobile and culturally porous- new combinations of local and transregional elements emerged

Studying Religion in the Indian Sub-continent: Some issues

- The non-Western religions are studied by Christian missionaries through the comparison model with the outlook that was ‘Western’ and ‘Christian’
- The Judeo-Christian model was not suitable for studying South Asian religions
- Religion in the Indian sub-continent was marked by competing models of divinity, diversity of practice, regional distinctiveness, inclusive religious identity
- It is only in the 20th century CE that the pluralist viewpoint dominated academic study of religion



Understanding Religion in India: Beyond a Catalogue of Religions

Judeo-Christian Religion Emphasises:	South Asian Religions ALSO Include …
Monotheism (belief in one creator god)	Multiple deities, local or regional deities
A founder (e.g., Jesus)	Inherited traditional practices; no founder
Faith/belief	Emphasis on ritual practice/actions
Predisposition to see religion of antiquity as superior	Contemporary "living" religion seen as a authoritative and relevant
Classical language as sacred (e.g., Latin) and textual authority (e.g., the Bible)	Authority derived from modern living languages, customary practice, oral tradition
Uniform and centralised community of believers	Local or regional communities united by language, practice, kinship ties, etc.
Identity belief-based and exclusive	Identity practice-based and inclusivist
Universalist—anyone can convert—active proselytisation	Not universalist, does not accept converts; membership by birth; no proselytisation

The meaning of 'religion' from a Judeo-Christian-Colonial perspective?

- Assumptions of Judeo-Christian model of religion hugely shaped understanding of "religion" and "religious identity" in South Asia from colonial times onwards
- From 1871 onwards, British categorised the Colonised populace according to caste and community in a vast census undertaking
- Despite varying status of caste groups and fluidity of religious identity from region to region, uniform categories were used
- Despite policy of non-interference in cultural and religious affairs, colonial administration enlivened perceptions of caste and community
- Philosophical assumptions behind the categories used in the census inherently problematic for South Asia
- Hardening of religious identities (Muslim OR Hindu OR Sikh, etc)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6VTzNaUGykQ

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=40C-seVJzTc